The Thumbprint of Mukhtar Mai

By Susan Yankowitz - based on conversations with Mukhtar Mai

MUKHTAR: My great-aunt had the honor of naming all the children in my family because she had none of her own. She called me Mukhtar, which means "powerful" or "self-respecting" and that always was strange for me, because I am very thin, and in *my* culture, a thin person is considered weak. My village is Meerwala in the southern part of Pakistan, one of the poorest areas in the Punjab. We are from the Gujars, a peasant tribe of low caste. I lived with my mother, father, four sisters, and two brothers. Like other girls, I played with dolls, climbed trees, and swam in the canal.

My village had no school, and no one in my family could read or write. I learned the same things my mother had learned, and her mother before her: how to do housework, fetch water from the pump, put the younger children to bed. I did not know that in other places, not so far away, girls were being educated. I was not unhappy because I did not realize I had been taught nothing about the world.

(Pause as she visibly thinks; then change of tone.) No, no, I **WAS** taught something . . . all girls were; I was taught silence, I was taught fear. I was taught that some people are high up and some are low down - and that my caste, my family, were at the bottom. I was taught to hide my face and bow my head, to say "yes," "yes," even when I felt "no" in my heart, to obey my parents, and stay away from boys.

INTRODUCTION

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MUKHTAR: [When] I was twenty-eight years old, some men of the Mastoi tribe come to our home and say that my twelve-year-old brother, Shakur, has committed ***zina*** with

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a girl from their clan and must go to jail. This crime they put on Shakur means rape or sex before marriage, and by the laws of Sharia it is punished by death. We are sure this is false. But what can we do? The Mastoi are a higher caste than we are, they are landowners, so whatever they say is law.

The men of the ***jirga,*** our village council, meet to discuss the situation, and finally we are told that I, Mukhtar, must ask forgiveness for my brother. If this will satisfy them, if this will free my brother from their hands, I am happy to do it. *(Gets Quran, begins her walk.)*

It is twilight when I begin walking toward the farm of the Mastois, holding my prayer book to my breast. I am not afraid. I have done no harm to anyone. With my father and uncle, I travel the dirt road and enter the Mastoi compound. The clan chief, Faiz Mohammad, and four other men are standing there with rifles.

(Kneeling.) I spread my shawl on the ground to show submission and silently recite a prayer: *Praise be to God, Lord of the Universe, Thee only do we worship and of thee only do we ask help* ... *(raises her head and speaks clearly)* If my brother has offended you, I ask pardon for his action and beg you to set him free.

Faiz shouts to his kinsmen: "There she is. Do what you want with her." Four men pull me by my hair and arms and drag me into a dark room. I am thrown onto a dirt floor ... a stable. The only animals there ... the only beasts! ... are those men. For more than an hour, I am raped by men of the Mastoi tribe. My father and uncle could do nothing for me. Men with shotguns force them to wait outside. They must have known what was happening, but they had no power.

Every woman, from the time she is a little girl, walks in terror of what happened to me. By the time we are eight years old, ten years old, we know that a man can grab us whenever he pleases and take us to some evil place where he will push us down ...

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break into our bodies ... destroy our childhoods and our futures.

When the men are finished with me, I am thrown outside. My uncle and father help me to my feet and support me to walk home, past hundreds of townspeople. No one says a word as I pass by; they all lower their eyes or stare at me with disgust. Now I am unclean and dishonored - in the eyes of the tribal elders, my family, and the villagers.

For the next few days no one talks to me about the thing that happened, and I say nothing. In my country, women do not share such disgrace with others. People will spit on me, on my parents and sisters ... I can spare everyone that misery by killing myself, I think; it might even be a relief for them ... *(Growing agitated.)* In Pakistan, staying alive is seen as more cowardly and shameful than the rape itself. I understood that the shame was not mine, but, I felt ashamed. I knew I should go on living but I felt so miserable that I wanted to die. But if I didn't die, what would I do with my life?

One idea kept pushing away the others: I could try to help the women of my country. Yes, maybe that was possible ... Because I knew that what happened to me was not God's will. Nowhere does the Quran approve of violence against women! So why do men act in such ways? Because women in Pakistan have no value and cannot bring their attackers to justice? Because we are too weak to fight back?

(Calming) So this is how I was thinking when I learned that my rape was not just an evil plot of the Mastois but had been ordered -- **ordered!** by the most honored men in my village, the tribal elders - *(Increasingly furious.)* The tribal council had declared that I should be gang-raped as punishment. An "honor revenge", they call it! How could they reach such a terrible decision? How?!

So I see I have no choice. I must stand up alone for myself. My mind was made up. I was ready to speak out. *(Again she begins to walk.)* Eight days after the rape, I travel

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the many miles to the police station in Jatoi. My father could have tried to stop me but no, he walks steadily beside me.

The policeman is sitting at his desk when I enter. He says, “We already know what happened. See?" and shoves a piece of paper at me. Words are written on it, but I do not know what they mean. How can I deny his report or defend myself? "Sign here and we will fill in the particulars."

My face burns red, I am so embarrassed that I do not know how to write my name. But he just laughs. "Use your thumbprint, like the other women. And he presses my thumb on an inkpad, then onto the bottom of the blank page. I have no idea what statement will appear above that signature.

This is when I realize why we **must** have knowledge. If you are educated, you can understand what is happening and fight for your rights. But when you are illiterate, you are like a dumb animal, so how can you stop the terrible things that fall down on you?

And the next morning, what a racket wakes me up! The dog is barking, chickens are squawking in the yard, reporters call out for me, women's groups, civil rights groups from all over the world ... ! The Pakistan Human Rights Commission has demanded a full investigation, and the press is supporting my lawsuit. Everyone wants to hear my story, because this is the first time that tribal elders in Punjab province have authorized a gang rape ***and*** the first time a woman is taking her case to court.

And from these strangers I learn about other violence. In Lahore, a woman asking divorce from a husband who beats her was murdered in her lawyer's office. A teen-aged girl's nose was cut off to punish her for holding hands with a boy from a neighboring tribe. Acid was thrown in the face of another girl who refused to marry an old man chosen by her family. In a village near Sukkur, three brothers burned their

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sister-in-law alive because they claimed she had been unfaithful. And always, always, it is a matter of honor! No one seems to find it strange that in all our history, only women and never a man have been punished for a so-called crime of honor!

And so I take my rapists to court, even though I hear they are laughing at the whole thing; but they do not laugh when the verdict is announced. The four rapists are condemned to death. I am told to report to a local office where I am given a check for half a million rupees - about eight thousand dollars - by a government minister - a woman!

"I don't need money. I need a school. A school for girls. We are so ignorant, we know nothing of the world. Girls must learn how to sign their names with a pen instead of a thumb. They must learn to read, to write, to know their rights as citizens. Help me. Help me to build a school." She says it is fine to use the money any way I choose. And so begins my new passion, my mission in life.

I hire a teacher and set up the school in a field of wheat and cotton. I start with only three, but every day more little girls turn up with their notebooks and pencils. They learn the usual subjects. But we also teach them that women are equal with men. All of us are human beings and we all must be treated with respect in society. And we read to them what the founding father of my country, Mohammad Ali Jinnah, said in 1944: "No nation can rise to the heights of glory unless its women are standing side by side with the men. It is a crime against humanity that our women are shut up within the four walls of the houses like prisoners."

Me, I don't cry anymore. And each morning when I rise, I thank God for the rewards of living. I have now opened three schools in Punjab province and they are for boys as well as girls, because boys too must learn that under Islam, under the law, women have the same rights they do. And in Meerwala, where I almost killed myself, I have built a real schoolhouse, with a library and six classrooms. The children come from

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many tribes, from low and high castes girls from the Gujars and even boys from the Mastois! We teach more than two hundred and sixty boys and four hundred girls.

And I am one of those girls. I was the first student in my own school, and now I am in the fifth grade. I will keep on studying but already I have learned this: Never, never will I need to use my thumb to sign my name. I am Mukhtar. Powerful. Self-respecting. Mukhtar!

CONCLUSION

In Pakistan today, women are still in peril. In international news . . . On July 21, 2021, 27-year-old Noor Muqaddam was brutally tortured and beheaded in the nation's capital – her crime, refusing to marry her murderer, Zahir Jaffer. The courts have yet to decide on the merits of the case.

And yet Pakistan is ranked only 6th on the scale of most dangerous countries for women. How can this be? The Human Rights Commission of Pakistan recorded 430 cases of honor killings in 2020 and during the first 4 months of this year, in Punjab alone, police have registered 53 cases of gang rape.

Education is a start, but Pakistan remains a culture that de-humanizes the female gender. And as long as this is so . . . Pakistan will continue to fail its women.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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